One of the options nevertheless remained ‘preemption on unambiguous warning’.[9] When Henry Kissinger, Richard Nixon’s national security adviser, later sought to reform the SIOP, he described the five options in the SIOP as a ‘horror strategy’ that contained ‘five options for massive retaliation.’[10] A 1975 Pentagon study concluded that US ‘Command Centers do not possess the combination of survivability and capability which is required for the conduct of limited strategic nuclear war’.[11]

By October 1961 the search for more flexibility had nevertheless translated into a more graduated approach to the use of nuclear weapons in a crisis over Berlin. This was embodied in a National Security Action Memorandum (NSAM 109). Kennedy made a point of sending the document to the Supreme Allied Commander Europe (SACEUR), General Norstad, in Paris (who was reluctant to use nuclear weapons on only a limited scale). More fundamental reform would later lead to the NATO strategy of Flexible Response in 1967.

Vienna

The inspiring rhetoric of John F. Kennedy’s inaugural address on 20 January 1961 disguised the absence of a coherent diplomatic strategy for meeting the seemingly intractable challenges of the Cold War. The prospect of a coherent diplomatic strategy was soon complicated, if not stymied, by the Bay of Pigs fiasco. Already concerned that Khrushchev might consider him inexperienced and irresolute in foreign affairs, one consequence of the Bay of Pigs was to heighten Kennedy’s anxieties and reduce his opportunities for diplomatic flexibility.

Kennedy wanted to meet Khrushchev to gain a better understanding of his adversary. He also hoped that a meeting might move forward negotiations on the possible neutrality of Laos and the negotiation of a nuclear test ban treaty. For Kennedy, it was a chance to address his concern that his inexperience in foreign policy must not be taken as a sign of weakness. Khrushchev had a different agenda. His key objective was resolving the problem of Berlin. The asymmetry of their expectations was crucial to the failure of the summit to reduce Cold War tensions.